CHAPTER 3

L A N D O F I S R A E L

ANCIENT EXPERIENCES

At the northern extremity of the ancient zone of Semitic settlement, there lies a "fertile crescent" of lands that have always been the envy of the nomadic and mountain peoples who live respectively on its southern and northern borders. The whole western horn of this crescent was known as Syria to the Romans. The part of the western horn south of Mount Hermon has been known as Palestine.

Palestine is one of the oldest homes of man. Cave deposits of human origin perhaps 150,000 years old have been found in several parts of the country. Both the Old and New Stone Ages are represented. About 3000 B.C. the country was already inhabited by a Semitic-speaking people identified as Canaanite down to the thirteenth century B.C., as Phoenician thereafter, and as Carthaginian in their most famous west Mediterranean colony. In the eighteenth century B.C. the Canaanites (under the leadership of the little-known Hyksos) participated in the conquest of Egypt. They were not expelled until about 1560 B.C.

The ancient Hebrews preserved a tradition according to which their forefather Abraham was "a fugitive Aramaean" from Harran, a northwestern Mesopotamian city that flourished in the nineteenth and eighteenth centuries B.C. Some of his descendants settled in the land of Canaan and adopted a Canaanite dialect.

Another strong tradition holds that part of the Hebrew people sojourned in Egypt. They may have entered the country with its Hyksos conquerors. The king who knew not Joseph was, in all probability, a native Pharaoh of the New Empire that followed the expulsion of the Hyksos. Moses and some of the Aaronids bear distinctively Egyptian names. Modern historical scholarship suggests that the Hebrew Exodus from Egypt took place between 1290 and